GOALS OF CARE



One in three high-risk patients choosing surgery will experience serious medical complications leading to long-term decline in health and quality of life. Often patients do not receive the information they need to make an informed decision about surgery. [1]

Essential communication regarding goals of care is essential for aligning surgical interventions with patient values, preferences, and clinical realities. Shared decision making is a collaborative process between clinicians and patients, which aims to select the most suitable treatment option based on best available evidence and informed patient preferences. [1]

Screening Tools

- Do you have an advanced care plan - a list of instructions to help guide a trusted person to make healthcare treatment decisions on your behalf if required?
- Have you identified a substitute decision maker - someone you trust to make healthcare treatment decisions on your behalf if you are unable to do it yourself?
- Is the patient at higher risk of perioperative complications? (e.g., advanced age, frailty, poor functional capacity, moderate/highly invasive surgery, multiple comorbidities)

Optimization is recommended for patients that answer No to question 1 or 2, or Yes to question 3.

Prehabilitation and Optimization Recommendations

Patient Education	⚙ Encourage patients to think about what matters most for their health. ⚙ Provide Advance Care Planning Guide and What Matters Most to Me worksheet ⚙ Refer to online patient resources
Preoperative Goals of Care Discussion	⚙ Lead with "What should I know about you as a person to help me take the best care of you that I can?" • Intended to open a patient-centered, narrative conversation that goes beyond symptoms and diagnoses. ⚙ Ask the following questions: • "What worries or concerns do you have about your upcoming surgery?" • "Can you share what you understand about your current health?" • "How do you hope that this surgery will help you?" • "Are there any outcomes from this surgery that you would consider unacceptable?" ⚙ Use the best-case scenario / worst-case scenario framework [2,3], a narrative and visual decision-support tool designed for high-stakes conversations. Refer to provider online resources.
Referral for Comprehensive Geriatric Assessment (CGA)	⚙ Consider preoperative assessment by Geriatrics to delineate risk